

news feed

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hypothesis

Philips iPronto Digital Home Controller

■ What is it?

The iPronto is designed to control your home entertainment systems, lighting, climate control and more, through one common interface.

■ How does it work?

It comes with an Intel PXA250 XScale embedded processor, runs Linux and has a 6.4-inch touch screen LCD interface. The Tao Java Virtual Machine provides a secure environment for executing applications. It also comes with an infrared interface for traditional remote controllers, and implements Wi-Fi (802.11b) connectivity and even an Ethernet port. If that's not enough, there is also a USB port as well as an MMC/SD card slot for connecting to other devices.

■ What does it do?

The interactive user interface lets you view electronic program guides, select media sources as well as surf the Net and access e-mail. The device has a built in microphone and speakers that should let you listen to MP3s streamed over the Internet. With a readily upgradeable internal software suite, the device can work with just about everything in the near future, from interfacing with digital cameras to automotive applications.

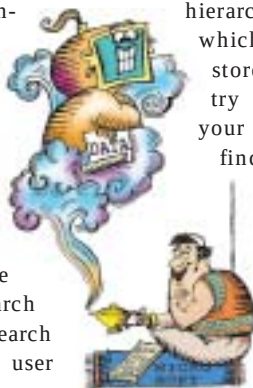
Making things better

Scientists at Microsoft's Research labs are busy cooking up new techniques that will make data easier to handle. Fast paced technology and the Internet are leaving vast repositories of unused data in their wake. Researchers have come up with search tools, better Web search techniques and user interfaces that will make finding relevant information easier.

A prototype application called Stuff I've Seen, is built to store all the data that has appeared on a computer terminal. Another one called Ask MSR lets you pose questions in a natural form such as, "What are the symptoms of SARS?"

All this is aimed at offering the user an alternative to the hierarchical means with which data is currently stored. New techniques try to make accessing your data much easier. To find your holiday snaps, you could search for images with a tropical background, instead of using filenames.

The company is also working on new types of user interfaces. In GWindows, one can scroll through files or move windows though a combination of voice commands and hand gestures. Motion tracking technology will eliminate the need for special gloves. A wrist-twisting motion could one day adjust the volume on your favourite media player.



ILLUSTRATIONS: Farzana Cooper

Rumours bite into Apple

The shares of Apple Computer fell by almost 9 per cent after the Los Angeles Times reported that the company is considering buying the world's largest record company, Universal Music Group. Universal is pegged to garner at least 6 billion dollars, according to analysts. Such an outflow of cash from the coffers of Apple, and the fact that they are likely to test uncertain

waters, led to the tumble of share prices.



Steve Jobs, CEO, Apple Computer

Digital entertainment forms the pivot to Apple's strategy, as they introduce digital lifestyle products, such as the popular iPod that stores thousands of songs.

Apple CEO Steve Jobs said, "Apple has never made any offer to invest in or acquire a major music company. We will abide by Apple's policy of not commenting on rumours."

Sans wires and faster

Intersil Corporation, designer and manufacturer of high performance analog and wireless networking solutions, announced a new WLAN software solution that improves 802.11g throughput by over 300 per cent. "PRISM Nitro provides up to 50 per cent greater throughput performance in homogenous 802.11g networks," said Larry Ciaccia, vice president and general manager for Intersil's Wireless Networking Products Group. This makes it an ideal solution for applications, such as CD-quality audio and DVD-quality video streaming.

Initial testing indicated up to a 3x performance improvement in 'worst-case' wireless networking systems. Such systems would be made up of predominantly 802.11b clients and access points with just a few 802.11g nodes.

The technology is a firmware upgrade that will be distributed through a driver suite.

snapshot

Over **950 million** messages are sent over **NTT-DoCoMo's** mobile e-mail service daily. Close to **80%** are unsolicited

Source: NTT-DoCoMo